these divided families and I took the Soviet decision as a positive signal before the summit.

In Geneva, we drove to our temporary home, la Maison de Saussure, a beautiful villa on Lake Geneva loaned to us by Prince Karim, Aga Khan, and his wife for the duration of the summit. The view from our window looking out across the villa's sweeping formal gardens and lake was spectacular.

The next day, we toured Villa Fleur d'Eau, a twenty-room château where our first meetings were to take place, then Nancy and I walked down to the lakeshore boat house where I had decided to invite Gorbachev for a chat. She agreed it was a perfect spot for the private meeting I wanted with him.

Usually at summit conferences, the real work is done in advance by diplomats and specialists on each side who, based on guidance from their superiors, do the spadework and work out any agreements that are to be signed at the meeting, after which the top leaders come in and preside over the formalities.

Starting with Brezhnev, I'd dreamed of personally going one-on-one with a Soviet leader because I thought we might be able to accomplish things our countries' diplomats couldn't do because they didn't have the authority. Putting that another way, I felt that if you got the top people negotiating and talking at a summit and then the two of you came out arm in arm saying, "We've agreed to this," the bureaucrats wouldn't be able to louse up the agreement. Until Gorbachev, I never got an opportunity to try out my idea. Now I had my chance.

Neither Nancy nor I slept very well as we waited for the meetings to begin, but I never felt tired. The juices were flowing. I wanted to get started. In a very real sense, preparations for the summit had begun five years earlier, when we began strengthening our economy, restoring our national will, and rebuilding our defenses. I felt ready.